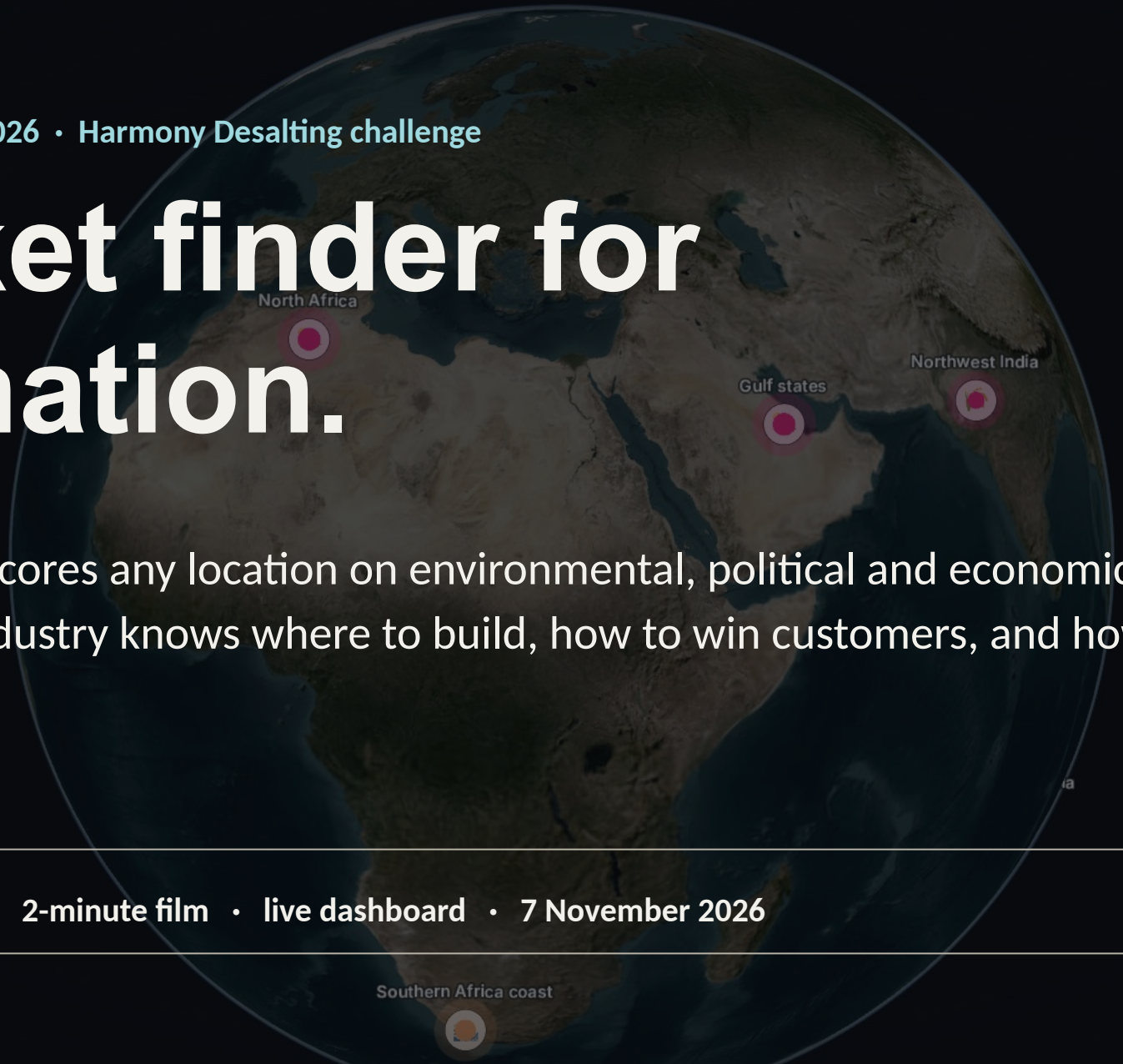
MIT Energy & Climate Hack 2026 · Harmony Desalting challenge

A market finder for desalination.



One dashboard that scores any location on environmental, political and economic uncertainty, so the industry knows where to build, how to win customers, and how sure it can be.

Team Sea Major · 9 slides · 2-minute film · live dashboard · 7 November 2026

Harmony Desalting: “What actions should the [desalination] industry take to secure our freshwater supplies in 2050 and beyond?”

The challenge, in Harmony's words

Reduce the uncertainty before you build.

"Setting aside technology development, what actions should the desalination industry take to secure our freshwater supplies in 2050 and beyond?"

Quantum Wei, Harmony Desalting

We read the problems behind that question across dozens of sources. Plants fail on uncertainty, not on technology. Three kinds decide whether the right plant gets built on time:

Environmental conditions

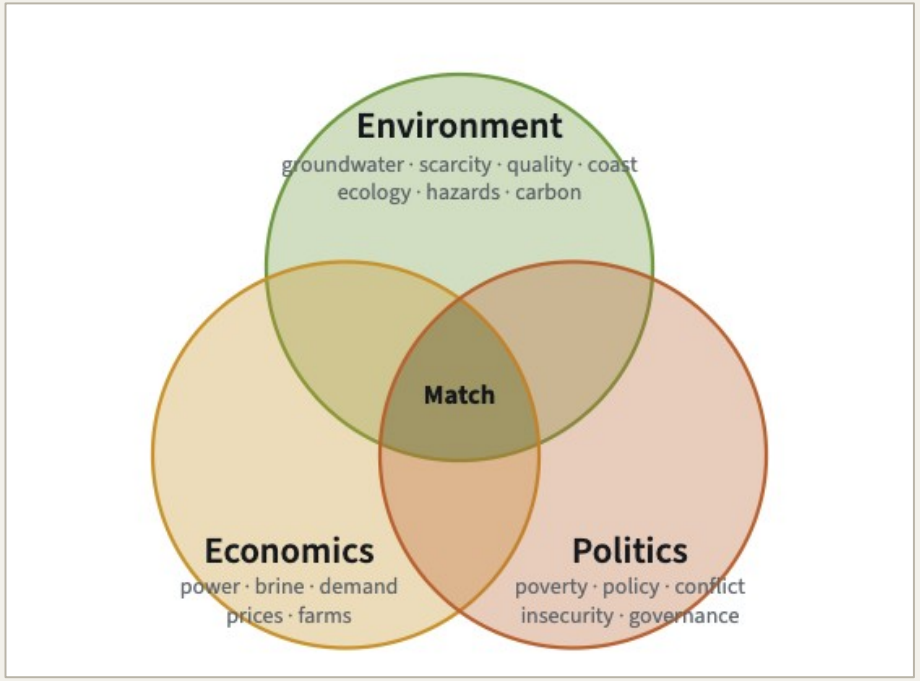
scarcity, groundwater, water quality, coast, ecology, hazards, clean energy

Political and governance conditions

governance, stability, shared rivers

Economic viability

ability to pay, energy cost, farm share, offtake

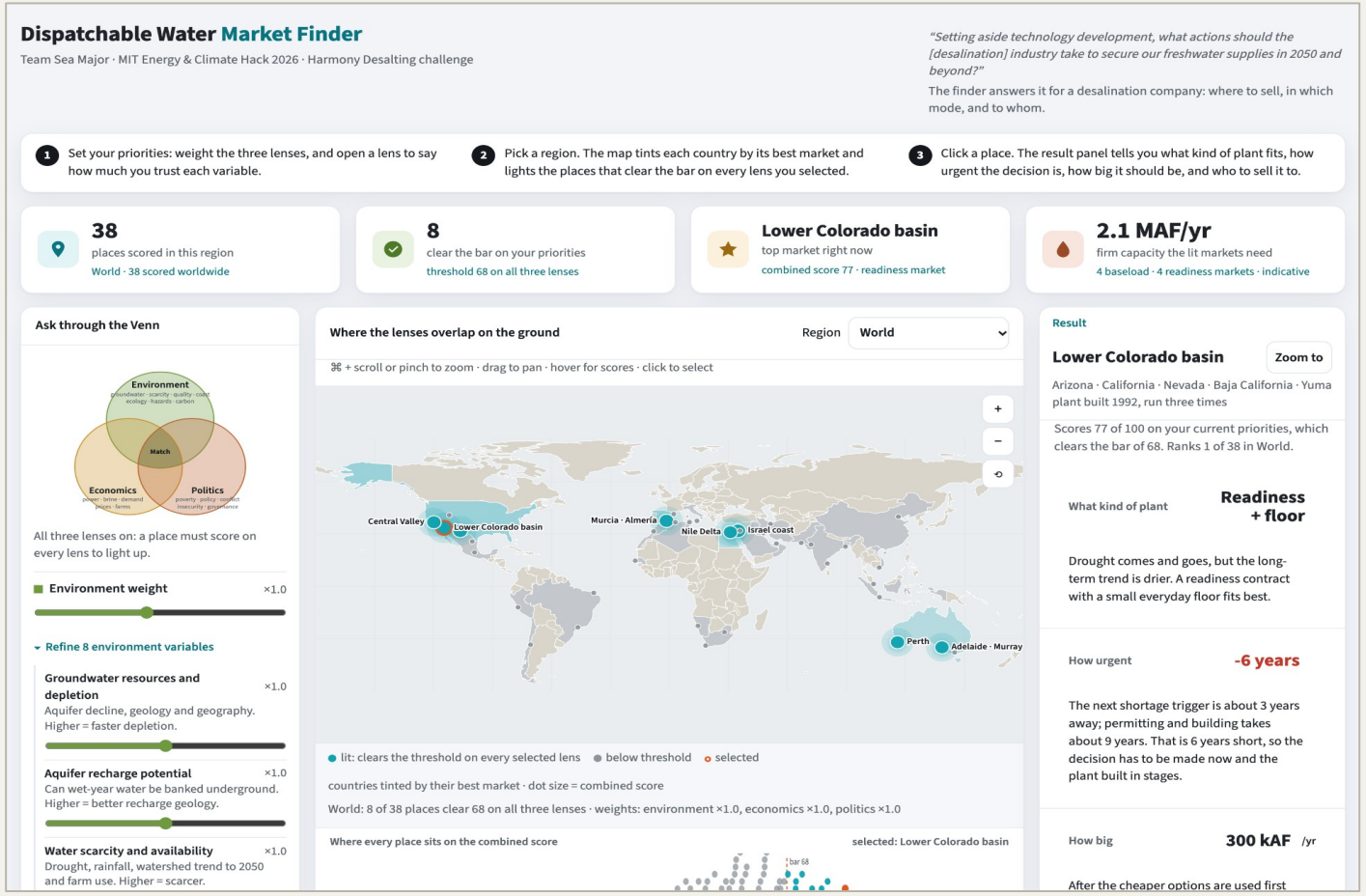


Where all three overlap is where a plant gets built, bought and paid for.

Three questions for the industry: where to build · how to acquire customers · how to reduce uncertainty

Our proposal: an adaptable model

Set your priorities. The model adapts.



1 Choose what matters

Weight the three lenses and your confidence in each variable. A social-impact fund and a desal company get different maps.

2 It scores every location

From public indices that already quantify these risks: WRI Aqueduct, WWF Water Risk Filter, Water Peace and Security, UN SDG 6, FAO AQUASTAT, NASA GRACE.

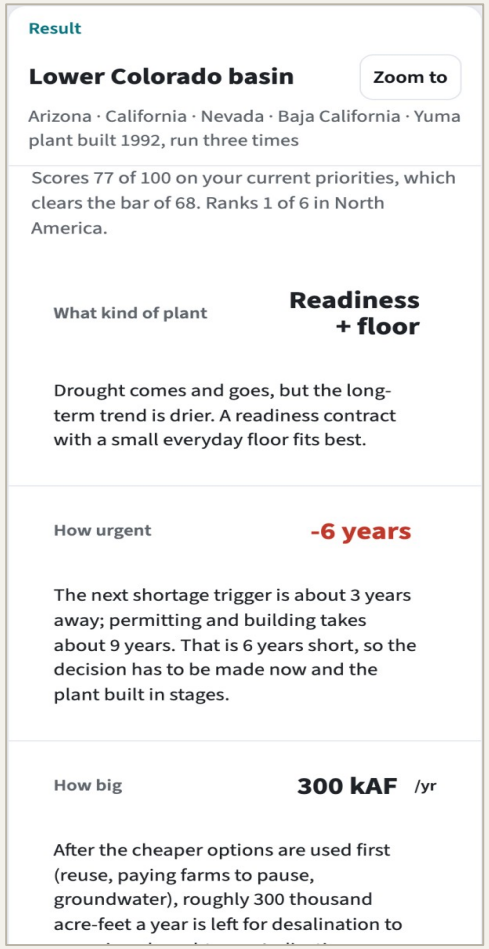
3 It ranks your region

Pick a region of interest and get the locations that fit your priorities, as investment opportunities with a score.

Prototype: the scoring methods exist (the WWF Water Risk Filter is the template); the full data back end is not built yet.

Case study: the tool applied to Yuma, Arizona

Set the toggles for a typical plant. Read the output.


Result

Lower Colorado basin Zoom to

Arizona · California · Nevada · Baja California · Yuma plant built 1992, run three times

Scores 77 of 100 on your current priorities, which clears the bar of 68. Ranks 1 of 6 in North America.

What kind of plant **Readiness + floor**

Drought comes and goes, but the long-term trend is drier. A readiness contract with a small everyday floor fits best.

How urgent **-6 years**

The next shortage trigger is about 3 years away; permitting and building takes about 9 years. That is 6 years short, so the decision has to be made now and the plant built in stages.

How big **300 kAF** /yr

After the cheaper options are used first (reuse, paying farms to pause, groundwater), roughly 300 thousand acre-feet a year is left for desalination to

Readiness

mode: backup with a baseload floor

−6 years

timing gap: trigger in ~3, build takes ~9

300 kAF/yr

the right size, after cheaper water

The business pitch it returns

Sell to the binational commission and Reclamation, as treaty compliance.

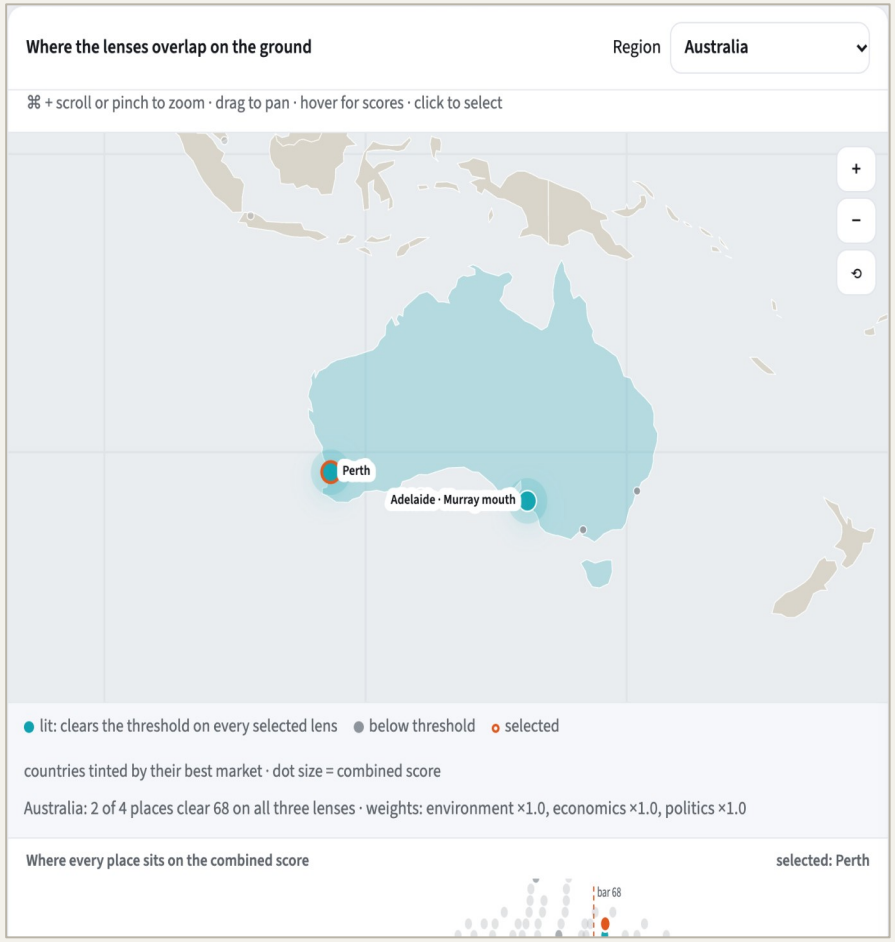
Water made at Yuma is water not taken from the shared river. Contract: readiness payments, modules on a Lake Mead trigger, then an exchange with the farms. Energy cost and the cheapest alternatives come with it.

Scored from real data

WRI Aqueduct baseline water stress (extremely high) · NASA GRACE groundwater decline · Oregon State TFDD: shared basin under the 1944 Treaty · World Bank governance · CCVI stability. Combined score 77 of 100, first in North America.

Does it work? The same tool, run on Australia

It returns the modes that worked.



	Tool says	What happened
Perth	**Everyday supply (baseload)**	Built 2006, before the crisis. Runs every year.
Melbourne	**Readiness contract**	Bought in a panic in 2007. Finished as the dams refilled. Idle five years.
Sydney	**Readiness contract**	Switched off in 2012, restarted on a rule in 2019.
Adelaide	**Readiness, then exchange**	Paid to run in 2019 so farmers upstream kept river water.

Same weights for all four. The one that failed, Melbourne, failed on timing, which is exactly the gap the tool reports.

Every way to get fresh water, cheapest first.

Method	What it is	Ballpark $ per acre-foot	kWh/m³	Drought-proof?	Precedent
Stop evaporation	Floating solar and canal lining; the big lakes lose a million acre-feet a year to the sun.	$200–400	~0	No: cuts losses, rain still decides	Project Nexus, California
Pay farms to pause	Paid fallowing and crop shifts; alfalfa is about a third of basin farm use.	$300–500	~0	No: demand response, not supply	Palo Verde fallowing
Reuse wastewater	Treated city and industrial water for farms, cooling and industry.	$600–1,200	0.3–0.6	Partly: sewage flows in a drought	Israel: ~85% reused
Treat farm drainage	Salty irrigation return flows, treated and used again.	$500–1,500	~1	Partly: drainage shrinks with farm cuts	Yuma, idle since 1992
Brackish aquifers	Inland desalination of salty groundwater.	$700–1,500	0.5–1.5	Yes, while the aquifer lasts	El Paso, Texas
Produced water	Oil and gas water, treated for farms or industry.	high today	1–3	Yes, small volumes	Cawelo, California
Potable reuse	Wastewater purified to drinking standard.	$1,500–2,500	1–1.5	Partly	Orange County; NEWater
Seawater desalination	The only source independent of rain, rivers and aquifers.	$2,000–3,000	3–4	Yes: the firm capacity	Carlsbad; Sorek, Israel

Ballpark ranges, verify before quoting. Saline agriculture, growing on salt water, is the 2050 play: it frees fresh water instead of making it.

To finance the firm rung: pay for readiness, not gallons · add modules on a trigger · if it rains, sell or bank the water

Harmony Desalting: “What actions should the [desalination] industry take to secure our freshwater supplies in 2050 and beyond?”

Impact

Timing, size and a payer, in numbers.

A$3B

paid before first water at Melbourne

five idle years at about A$600M a year

⅔

of the capital not committed when you build in stages

first module on the trigger, the rest later

100 kAF

a year kept in Lake Mead when Yuma runs

about the indoor use of 300,000 households

9 markets

lit by the tool, each with a buyer and a payer

on the default priorities, worldwide

Order-of-magnitude estimates from the Australia cases and Reclamation’s Yuma figures.

Path to implementation

Start at Yuma.

Built 1992, run three times in thirty years. All three uncertainties in one idle plant, and Harmony already pilots there.

2026	Run the tool on the Lower Colorado. Publish the map.	Harmony, with CAP, Metropolitan and SNWA
2026–27	Draft the readiness contract. Price the Ciénega offset.	Reclamation, the three states, IBWC and CILA
2027–29	Pilot one module on a Lake Mead trigger.	Reclamation and Harmony
2030+	Credit the first exchange. Repeat in the next markets the tool lights up.	Basin authorities, development banks

Known unknowns: refurbishment cost in the hundreds of millions, NEPA review, the wetland offset with Mexico.

Next steps and team

With more time, and who we are.

Build the data back end

Pull the indices live: Aqueduct, Water Risk Filter, Water Peace and Security, SDG 6, AQUASTAT, GRACE.

More calibration cases

Cape Town, Barcelona, Chennai, Carlsbad.

Talk to the people at Yuma

Reclamation’s office and Harmony’s pilot team: cost and the wetland offset.

Team Sea Major

Mayank D.

Carnegie Mellon · energy systems · finder, film and deck

Tanvir Kabir

Water diplomacy and sources

Teammate 3

Fill in: name and role

Teammate 4

Fill in: name and role

Live dashboard: kugel-blitz-13.github.io/dispatchable-water Sources: aqueduct.wri.org · riskfilter.org (WWF) · waterpeacesecurity.org · sdg6data.org · fao.org/aquastat · nasagrace.unl.edu · climate-conflict.org · usbr.gov (Yuma)